# Bullet Always Wins

## By Erik Christian Hanson

***CHARACTERS***

- *TEACHER -- any age, female, any race.*
- *BULLET -- any age, any gender, any race.*

***TIME:*** *A few days after yet another school shooting.*
***AUTHOR'S NOTE:*** *Teacher is rambling due to her mental state. She never acknowledges the presence of Bullet.*

## INTRODUCTION

*According to an Education Week analysis, in 2022 fifty-one school shootings took place on K-12 campuses -- the most in a single year since 2018. The tragedy at Robb Elementary School in Uvalde, Texas, was the **deadliest** school shooting since Sandy Hook in 2012 -- 19 children and two teachers were killed. Since then, President Joe Biden signed into law the first major federal gun legislation in nearly 30 years. The bipartisan bill includes measures to keep weapons out of the hands of dangerous people as well as hundreds of millions of dollars in additional funding for school safety and mental health resources.**

*Fast forward to 2023. With the new law and additional funding, the situation has improved, right? **No.** According to the most recent data compiled by CNN, as of October 3, 2023, **at least** 39 school shootings have occurred at America's K-12 schools so far this year.*** *It is clear that more must be done. Until we pass comprehensive gun control in the US the . . .*

*Bullet Always Wins by Erik Christian Hanson*

*Lights up. A dark room. A TEACHER stares off into space. A BULLET, shiny and lethal, is in the corner.*

**TEACHER:** The bullet missed my face by a hair.

**BULLET:** I was closer than that.

**TEACHER:** I can still hear the ringing. *(A prolonged ringing sound comes from BULLET's direction.)*

**BULLET:** That was me, sorry. *(He laughs.)*

**TEACHER:** Why can't I get it out of my head?!

**BULLET:** It is my intention to haunt you.

**TEACHER:** I . . .

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**BULLET:** And every other breathing person.

**TEACHER:** I . . .

**BULLET:** Spit it out.

**TEACHER:** I don't think I should set foot inside a school again.

**BULLET:** I second that notion.

**TEACHER:** I can't set foot inside a school again.

**BULLET:** That was my goal.

**TEACHER:** But I have to.

**BULLET:** You are not ready.

**TEACHER:** I cannot let this win.

**BULLET:** I always win.

**TEACHER:** My coworkers . . .

**BULLET:** Plenty of them are dead.

**TEACHER:** . . . would want me . . .

**BULLET:** I got nine of them.

**TEACHER:** . . . the students would want . . .

**BULLET:** And sixteen of those little buggers.

**TEACHER:** . . . me. . .

**BULLET:** They would want you to quit.

**TEACHER:** I need to be strong.

**BULLET:** Strong is overrated.

**TEACHER:** I need to . . .

**BULLET:** Quit.

**TEACHER:** I . . .

**BULLET:** QUIT.

**TEACHER:** I . . .

**BULLET:** Three of your coworkers did.

**TEACHER:** . . . need to be a symbol of . . .

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**BULLET:** They left the field of education for good.

**TEACHER:** . . . strength.

**BULLET:** What strength exists in that choice?

**TEACHER:** I . . .

**BULLET:** Because of me, the school is bringing in extra counselors and therapy dogs.

**TEACHER:** This is what teachers do.

**BULLET:** Teachers are going to leave their profession in droves.

**TEACHER:** Teachers keep going amidst all odds.

**BULLET:** Perhaps, but most teachers now live with the daily fear that I provide. All schools will be shut down after my work is done.

**TEACHER:** I have to join a group that says, "No, this will not continue.

**BULLET:** *(Amused)* Is there a group out there that says that?

**TEACHER:** This cannot continue.

**BULLET:** Oh, but it will.

**TEACHER:** We can't let it.

**BULLET:** You and others are no match.

**TEACHER:** We . . .

**BULLET:** Should retire.

**TEACHER:** . . . must find ways to . . .

**BULLET:** There are no ways. There is only surrender.

**TEACHER:** . . . protect our children's futures.

**BULLET:** They have no futures.

**TEACHER:** That is all that matters.

**BULLET:** Self-preservation is what matters, honey.

**TEACHER:** They are all that matter.

**BULLET:** They are not worth your sacrifice.

**TEACHER:** They . . .

**BULLET:** Mean nothing.

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**TEACHER:** . . . are. . .

**BULLET:** Ants in the overall scheme of things.

**TEACHER:** I have to do something!

**BULLET:** You have to do something? You must do something? I'll tell you what to do. You do this: buy a plane ticket in three days. My next shooting will occur 1,211 miles from here. Do your best to stop it. *(Laughs)* If you fail, do not fret because the shooting after that will be 379 miles from here. Are you willing to travel to stop me? Are you that committed to this cause? Short of that, you should take early retirement and reserve a stool at the local bar. Current happy hour prices are mind-blowing.

**TEACHER:** I will be strong. . .

**BULLET:** Waste of your energy.

**TEACHER:** I will take a more active role in the lives of my students . . .

**BULLET:** Waste of your time.

**TEACHER:** I will. . .

**BULLET:** Go through life thinking you can change a force as strong as I am, but you will be proven wrong in the end and you know it. Deep down, you know it.

**TEACHER:** I . . .

**BULLET:** Know it.

**TEACHER:** I don't know!

**BULLET:** You do know.

**TEACHER:** What can I do?

**BULLET:** Nothing.

**TEACHER:** What should I do?

**BULLET:** Ab-solutely nothing.

**TEACHER:** Why?

**BULLET:** Because I always win and you always lose.

**TEACHER:** The world isn't fair.

**BULLET:** Duh.

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**TEACHER:** The world . . .

**BULLET:** Is a series of stories made up of people's daily suffering.

**TEACHER:** . . . needs a makeover.

**BULLET:** I am in the process of giving it said makeover. Want to hear how many I will take at the next shooting?

**TEACHER:** The second amendment . . .

**BULLET:** Is a thing of freaking beauty.

**TEACHER:** . . . needs . . .

**BULLET:** Spoiler alert: it will never be modified.

**TEACHER:** . . . to be amended . . .

**BULLET:** The powers that be will never allow it.

**TEACHER:** . . . the psychiatric field needs . . .

**BULLET:** Even with better and more timely evaluations, I will be victorious. Have you seen what these counselors do with the kids?

**TEACHER:** They'll . . .

**BULLET:** Talk about emotions. Tell the little kiddos not to get stuck on their emotions, play a social-slash-board game, and then send them back to class with a sticker.

**TEACHER:** But counselors are not the problem.

**BULLET:** They're part of it.

**TEACHER:** It has to change. Everything needs to change.

**BULLET:** Be a part of the so-called change all you like, the results will be the same.

**TEACHER:** I am going to lead that change.

**BULLET:** Lead away.

**TEACHER:** I am that change.

**BULLET:** All righty . . .

**TEACHER:** I hope I am that change.

**BULLET:** You won't be, but it's fun to dream.

**TEACHER:** Maybe this has all been a dream.

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**BULLET:** I am sorry to report that it is all quite real, and that it is going to get much worse from here on out. More tears. More bloodshed. More confusion. More chaos. More rage.

**TEACHER:** A dream that I will emerge from and . . .

**BULLET:** You may have emerged, but you have entered a nightmare, dear. There are no exit doors for this one because I tossed out all the keys.

**TEACHER:** I can . . . conquer this.

**BULLET:** Humans don't defeat bullets.

**TEACHER:** I . . .

**BULLET:** will earn an "A" for trying.

**TEACHER:** can do this. I will do this.

**BULLET:** I wish you luck. Truly. The best of luck.

*(He snorts. TEACHER scans her surroundings, hoping a positive answer will come.)*

*(Blackout.)*

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Erik Christian Hanson***
***Book: The Best New Ten-Minute Plays 2021, Pg 51-58***
***ISBN: 978-1493060450***
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***Sources for information contained in the Introduction***
***NOTE: This information will need to be updated for currency.***

**** School Shootings This Year: How Many and Where***
***https://www.edweek.org/leadership/school-shootings-this-year-how-many-and-where/2023/01***

***** School shootings in the US: Fast facts by Alex Leeds Matthews, CNN***
***https://www.cnn.com/2023/09/22/us/school-shootings-fast-facts-dg/index.html***

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